

Game Analysis : Dark Souls

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Introduction:

Dark Souls is a game franchise that has become a household name of sorts. A dark fantasy role-playing game set in Lordran, dark souls gained its notoriety as one of the most difficult video games out there. Players navigate through hostile environments, fight powerful enemies, collect “souls” which work as experience and currency, all while repeatedly dying to learn how the game works. Despite this seemingly high barrier of entry, Dark Souls remains one of the most beloved games of all time. Why? Some would say it’s due to its incredible lore and worldbuilding, or perhaps the reason is it’s simple yet elegant gameplay loop, while others may find the challenge itself appealing.

Today, I will be specifically analysing “Dark Souls 1” from a psychological point of view, exploring how various psychological concepts have been applied throughout the game to build its unique yet addicting experience. I believe that Dark Souls has many great examples of psychological concepts, from obvious ones such as conditioning players, to less obvious ones like engaging memory as well as directly challenging the player’s motivation. Taking everything into account, I will attempt to build a clear image of Dark Souls, one of my favourite games, to you.

Operant Conditioning: Consequences, Souls, and Limited Healing

Perhaps the most obvious concept involved, operant conditioning is a huge part of Dark Souls. The idea of learning through consequence is present in many games, but in Dark Souls, some may say it is a core focus. It is used in many systems, such as the souls system, death system and the estus flask system.

When players defeat any enemy, they will gain souls, which can then be used to either level up at bonfires(checkpoints) or to purchase items from merchants. This works as positive reinforcement. If I approach an enemy carefully, blocking and dodging when necessary and win the fight, I gain something valuable in the form of souls. In this way, careful play and successful play is reinforced.

The same system also punishes careless behaviour. When a player dies, they drop all of the souls. This is only a temporary loss as if players manage to return to the same spot again, they can reclaim it. However, if they were to die again before reclaiming, those souls would be lost forever. This creates a very strong psychological consequence for recklessness. Players quickly learn that rushing fights, ignoring stamina and panicking can lead to significant loss of progress. The following image shows a player trying to retrieve lost souls after death, with the glowing light being the dropped souls. (EditPiaf, 2024).



Figure 1.

What makes this even more interesting is that this makes death not just a punishment, but a feedback as well. During my first playthrough of the game, when I arrived in the notorious “BlightTown”, I attempted to rush through the area, ignoring the monsters. Of course, I ended up dying after being cornered by all the monsters. This taught me that I had to approach the area carefully, to clear monsters before continuing in order to make sure I did not end up in the same situation again, and so that I can retrieve my souls safely. This works nicely as death will no longer feel like an instantaneous punishment, but more of feedback on what to do next. Instead of simply rage quitting after dying, players get a second chance to think about what went wrong and change their behaviour to fix it.

The estus flask system further strengthens this. In Dark Souls, healing is restricted to a limited resource known as the “Estus Flask” that can only be replenished at checkpoints. This, paired with no natural healing, makes taking damage that much more punishing. Each hit taken reduces the amount of total health players have for the rest of the area. If I take too much damage too early on, I may be left with no healing way before reaching the next checkpoint. On top of this, healing isn’t instantaneous, but instead has a wind-up animation. In a fight, healing at the wrong moment can lead to more damage and even death, training players to not panic-heal but instead wait for a safe opening. This heavily reinforces careful play and risk assessment.

Overall, Dark Souls use operant conditioning by connecting actions to consequence. The game doesn’t explain every lesson, it makes the players learn it through the hard way.

Cognitive Load and Procedural Memory: Managing Combat Under Pressure

Another heavily used concept, memory is often applied in Dark Souls. Players often have to manage resources such as resources like health, stamina, healing items while at the same time reading attack patterns and juggling between multiple enemies. This is precisely the concept of working memory. Over time, repeated practice also develops procedural memory, where actions become more automatic.

The combat of dark souls places heavy pressure on working memory. As previously mentioned, players have tons to keep note of during a fight, this paired with the already challenging and punishing enemies ends up being very overwhelming. Limited healing also adds to this mental pressure. During a fight, I as the player not only have to think about whether I can survive this fight, but also if I would have enough healing left for the rest of the area. This makes every encounter part of a larger calculation. I have to keep in mind the distance from each checkpoint, how many enemies there are between them, and whether it is even worth it to use healing items.

An early boss fight, the “Bell Gargoyles” , displays this clearly. Having multiple enemies, changing attack patterns and tight healing windows, this fight may feel very oppressive and chaotic. The sheer amount of information to keep track of can be overwhelming. This can be seen in the Eurogamer screenshot of gameplay (Ahmed, 2018). However, after repeated attempts, we can start to recognise some patterns, learn which animations signal danger, when the boss is vulnerable, and when healing is safe.



Figure 2.

At this juncture, the role of procedural memory becomes important. Through practice, fundamental mechanics like dodging, blocking, and parrying transition from conscious efforts into automatic responses. Eventually, the need to deliberately process every button press diminishes. Consider, for instance, a boss encounter that has been attempted numerous times, the player eventually avoids a recognizable strike almost by instinct alone. The boss hasn't gotten easier, the player's reactions have simply improved. This makes victory feel earned and rewarding as it comes from actual skill development.

Dark Souls also makes use of spatial memory. Since Dark Souls 1 lacks an in-game map or UI such as objective markers, the players must remember routes, enemy placements, traps, shortcuts and safe areas. Going from a bonfire to a boss becomes part of the challenge. Sen's Fortress is a good example. The area contains swinging blades, narrow walkways, pressure plates and enemies placed in dangerous positions. It is a very punishing area that will likely kill you many times. However, each attempt gives information. Where the pressure plate is, the timing of the blades, enemy position, how the walkways connect, all this information can be gathered from the various runs. Eventually, the once confusing area becomes manageable as the player managed to build a mental map from past experiences.

In conclusion, Dark Souls challenges working memory by forcing players to manage various elements in a high pressure scenario. Through practice, some of these elements become procedural memory. The player becomes better because their mind and body learn to adapt to the game's pressure.

Motivation and Hollowing: The Will to Continue

The final concept, and perhaps the most interesting, is motivation. As a challenging game by nature, motivation becomes extremely important because it directly relates to whether the player continues or gives up. Players need to feel some kind of drive to keep going, especially when the game repeatedly kills them or blocks their progress. Dark Souls does this in multiple ways, such as through rewards, new areas, and boss victories, but I think it is done best through the game's narrative.

In Dark Souls, there is a unique concept known as "Hollowing." For context, many people in Lordran, including the player character, are affected by the Undead curse. These Undead are unable to die permanently, meaning they resurrect after death. However, this immortality comes at a cost. Those who lose their purpose, will, or direction eventually become Hollow, returning as mindless and aggressive versions of themselves. Because of this, Hollowing can be understood as a loss of will, identity, and motivation.

This narrative idea connects very closely to the player's experience. Dark Souls is a tough game, and there are many moments where continuing feels almost impossible. I have personally come close to quitting several times when facing a difficult boss or entering an intimidating area with barely any Estus left. In these moments, the player is placed in a similar position to their character. The character is trying to continue through a dying world without losing purpose, while the player is trying to continue through repeated failure without losing motivation. In a world full of Hollowed Undead, the player is constantly being tested by frustration, confusion, and defeat. NPCs constantly remind you to not go hollow, as seen in Figure 3(CrispP_bacon, 2024). To "go Hollow" is therefore often treated by the Dark Souls community as a metaphor for quitting the game.



Figure 3.

The game supports this motivation through both external and internal rewards. External motivation comes from things like souls, weapons, armour, boss rewards, and access to new areas. These rewards give the player clear reasons to continue. However, the more powerful motivation often becomes internal. After dying to a boss many times, finally winning feels satisfying not just because of the reward, but because the player knows they improved. The victory feels earned.

This also connects to self-efficacy, which is the belief that success is possible. Dark Souls slowly builds this belief through small signs of progress. Even if the player dies repeatedly, they may survive longer, dodge more attacks correctly, use fewer Estus, or reach a later phase of the fight. These small improvements tell the player that the challenge is not impossible. They are getting closer.

Throughout the game, Hollowing gives narrative meaning to this struggle. The story is not only about defeating monsters or reaching the next area. It is also about holding onto purpose in a world built around death, decay, and failure. When the player keeps going after repeated deaths, they are resisting Hollowing both narratively and psychologically. This makes motivation one of the strongest psychological concepts in Dark Souls, because the game does not only ask whether the character can continue. It also asks whether the player can.

Conclusion

In conclusion, Dark Souls is not beloved simply because it is difficult. Its challenge works because it is built around psychological systems that make failure feel meaningful rather than pointless. Through operant conditioning, the game rewards careful play and punishes reckless decisions using souls, bloodstains, bonfires, shortcuts, and limited healing. Through cognitive load and procedural memory, it forces the player to manage stamina, Estus, enemy movement, timing, and positioning until repeated practice turns panic into skill. Finally, through Hollowing, Dark Souls connects its narrative directly to motivation. The player is not only guiding an Undead character through Lordran, but also personally facing the temptation to give up after repeated failure. This is what makes the experience so unique and addictive. The game does not simply become easier, instead, the player changes. They become more patient, observant, confident, and motivated to continue. In that sense, Dark Souls turns death into feedback, and that is what makes its experience so memorable.

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